While Bhindranwale was still in detention in the Lala Jagat Narain murder case, the Akali Dal leadership had, in September 1981, submitted to the government a list of forty-five demands segmented under four categories: religious, political, economic and social. The first of the many rounds of talks between the government and senior Akali Dal leaders was held on 16 October 1981, one day after Bhindranwale was exonerated of the murder charge and released from detention. Incidentally, Zail Singh made a statement on 15 October 1981 that Bhnidranwale was being released in Jagat Narain's murder case, as no incriminating evidence was found against him. [1] The meeting was held in the prime minister's office in Parliament House. The Akali Dal was represented by Harchand Singh Longowal, Parkash Singh Badal, Gurcharan Singh Tohra, Surjit Singh Barnala and Balwant Singh. Indira Gandhi was assisted by Cabinet Secretary C.R. Krishnaswamy Rao Sahib, her Principal Secretary P.C. Alexander and Home Secretary T.N. Chaturvedi. [2]

In the meanwhile, the Akalis had reduced their original forty-five demands presented to the government in September 1981 to fifteen. One of the demands was the release of Bhindranwale, which had become infructuous as he had already been released. The religious demands included permission for Sikhs to carry the kirpan (a short, curved dagger) on domestic and international flights; passing of an All India Gurudwara Act; grant of Holy City status to Amritsar; installation of a radio station at Harmandir Sahib in the Golden Temple complex for live broadcast of kirtan; and renaming of the Flying Mail (train) as Golden Temple Express.

The political and economic demands included devolution of some Central powers to Punjab, as per the provisions of the Anandpur Sahib Resolution, merger of Punjabi-speaking areas of the neighbouring states into Punjab, licence for opening a new bank under Sikh management, and remunerative prices for agricultural produce by linking them to the price index of industrial production. In addition, the transfer of Chandigarh, joint capital of Punjab and Haryana, to Punjab was a major issue.

The meeting of 16 October took up only the religious demands and the transfer of Chandigarh to Punjab. P.C. Alexander wrote in his memoirs, 'The political and economic demands were never